

COMMUNICATION SKILLS FOR PHARMACISTS

Patient Centered Communication

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The Communication Model

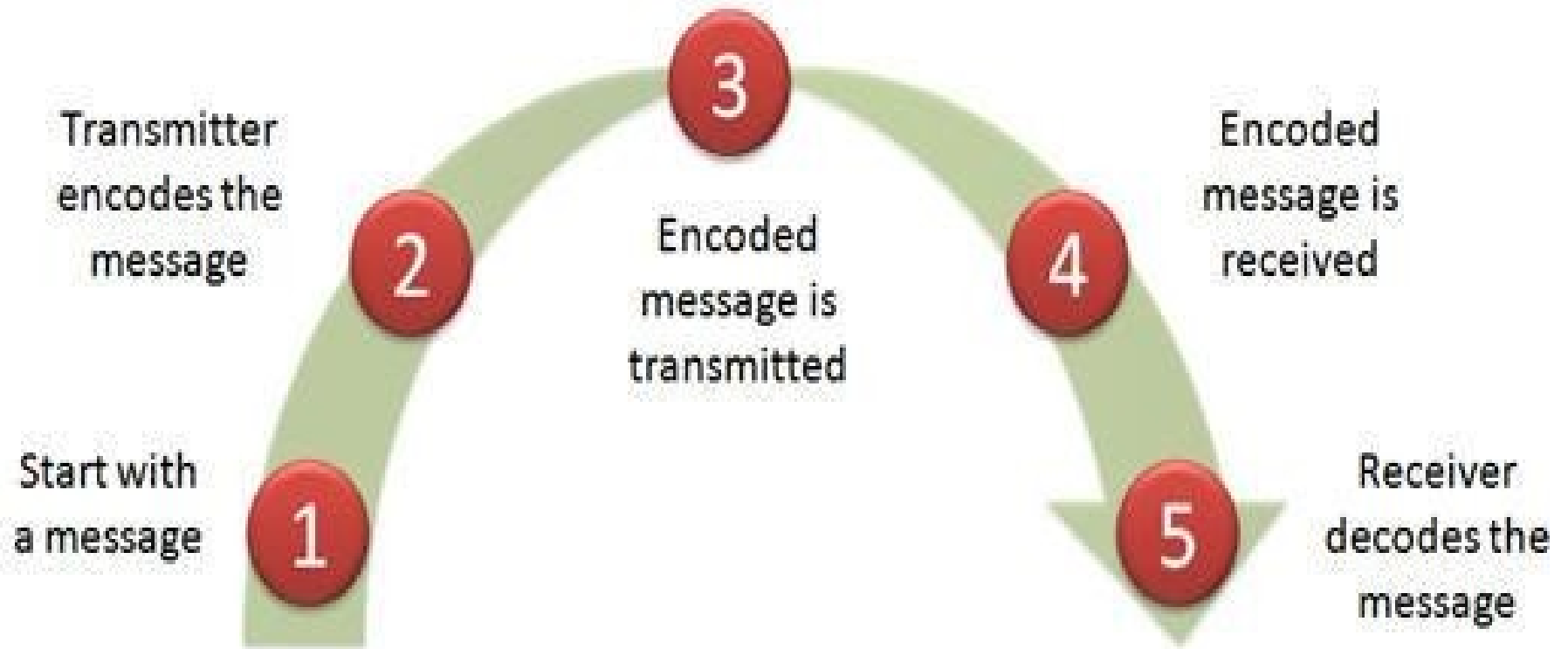


Introduction

- The exchange of information
- Vital part of everyday life
- The word communication comes from Latin word "communicare"= meaning "to share".

Introduction...

Basic Communication Process



Introduction...

Communication comes in many forms:

- Verbal (sounds, language, and tone of voice)
- Aural (listening and hearing)
- Non-verbal (facial expressions, body language, and posture)
- Written (journals, emails, and text messages)
- Visual (signs, symbols, and pictures)

Patient Centered Communication in Pharmacy Practice

- To meet their professional responsibilities, pharmacists have become more patient-centered in their provision of pharmaceutical care.
- Pharmacists have the potential to contribute even more to improved patient care through efforts to **reduce medication errors** and **improve the use of medications by patients**.

Patient centered communication in Pharmacy practice...

- **Medication Centered**  **Patient Centered**

Responsibility: Ensures patients obtain the maximum benefit from medications

- Patient-centered care depends on:
 - ✓ Pharmacist's ability to develop trusting relationships with patients.
 - ✓ Open exchange of information.
 - ✓ Shared decision-making process regarding treatment.
 - ✓ Help the patient in reaching therapeutic goals

Cont...

- Using effective communication skills is essential in the provision of patient care.
- Pharmacists must participate in activities that enhance **patient adherence** and **the wise use of medication**
 - (i.e., focus on patient-centered elements including patient understanding and actual medication-taking behaviors).

Cont...

- Patient-centered care depends on your ability to develop trusting relationships with patients,
 - to engage in an open exchange of information, to involve patients in the decision-making process regarding treatment,
 - and to help patients reach therapeutic goals that are understood and endorsed by patients as well as by health care providers.
- Effective communication is central to meeting these patient care responsibilities in the practice of pharmacy.

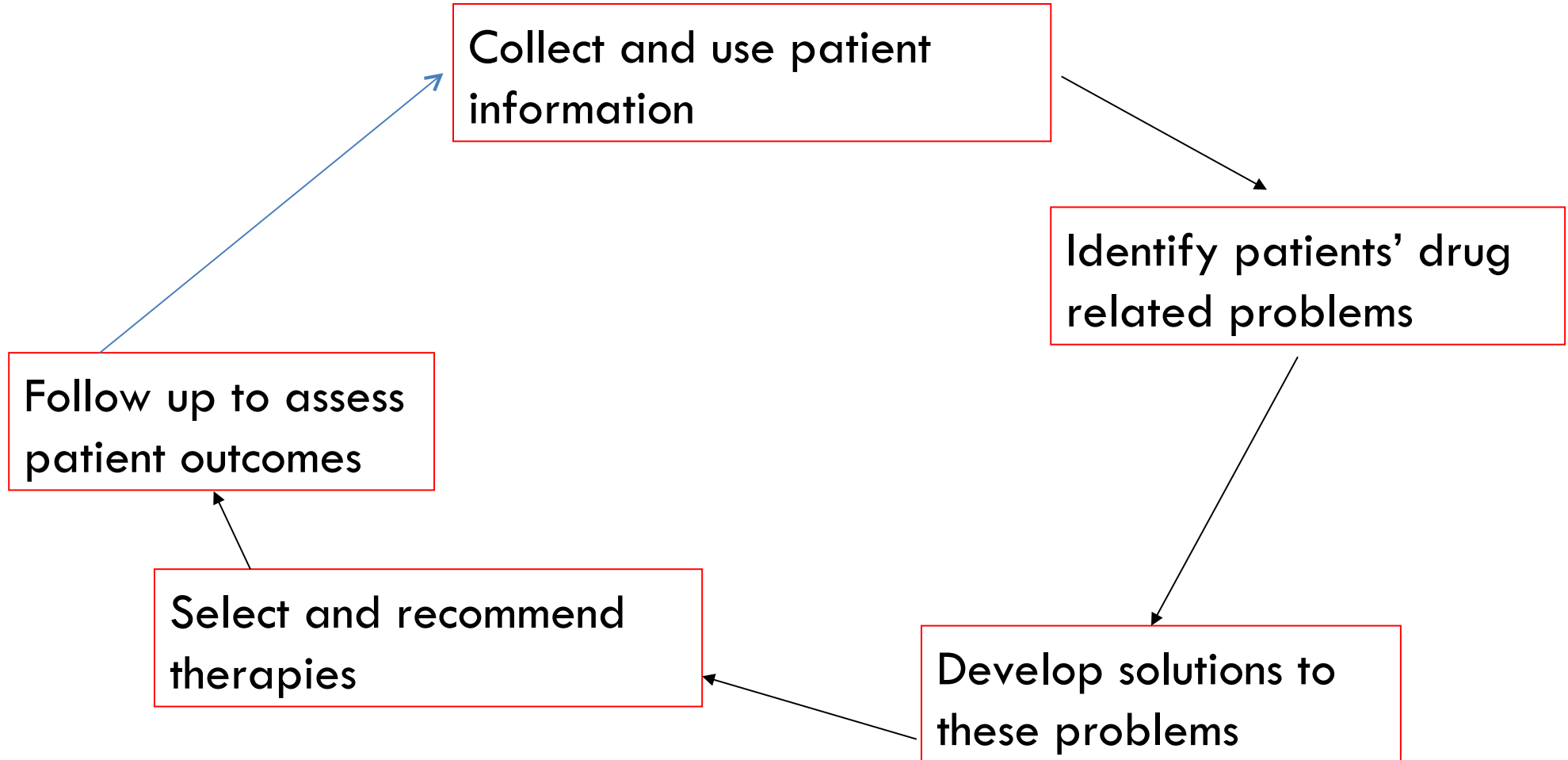
Pharmacists' Responsibility in Patient Care

- The incidence of preventable adverse drug events and the cost to society associated with medication-related morbidity and mortality is of growing concern.
- The Institute of Medicine (IOM) report on patient safety concluded that **medication-related errors** are among the most prevalent errors in medical care.

Cont...

- Reduce the incidence of both medication-related errors and drug-related illness
- Reducing the cost to society associated with medication-related morbidity and mortality
- Improves patients' quality of life

The Pharmacy Care Process



What to collect??

Patient information

- Full name
- Address and phone
- Date of birth (DOB) / age
- Gender
- Drug list (profile) including all OTC, Rx, herbal supplements, etc.
- Chronic medical conditions (diagnoses)
- Keep for **2 years**

Prospective DUR

- Over / underutilization
- Therapeutic duplications
- Drug-disease interactions
- Drug-drug interactions
- Incorrect dosage or duration of treatment
- Drug allergy interactions

Patient Counseling

- Intended use and expected action
- Route, dosage form, dosage, and administration schedule
- Special directions for preparation, storage, or administration
- Precautions to be observed while taking
- Common side effects, how to avoid or action required if they occur
- Techniques for self-monitoring of drug therapy
- Potential interactions or therapeutic contraindications
- What to do if you miss a dose....etc.

Importance of communication in meeting patient care responsibilities

- The communication process between health professionals and patients serves two primary functions:
 1. It establishes the ongoing relationship between the provider and the patient
 2. It provides the exchange of information necessary to assess a patient's health condition, implement treatment of medical problems, and evaluate the effects of treatment on a patient's quality of life.

Cont...

- Your goal is not to get patients to do as they are told (i.e., comply), but to help them reach intended treatment outcomes.
- Providing information or trying to improve adherence must be seen as a means to reach a desired outcome, rather than being an end in itself.

Providing Patient-Centered Care

The Pharmacists must be able to:

1. Understand the illness experience of the patient
2. Perceive each patient's experience as unique
3. Foster a more equal relationship with patients
4. Build a “**therapeutic alliance**” with patients to meet mutually understood goals of therapy
5. Develops self-awareness of personal effects on patients

Understanding Medication Use from the Patient Perspective

- Models of the prescribing process that are **practitioner-centered** have primarily focused on decisions made and actions taken by physicians and other health care providers
 - Patients acted up on
 - The patients were viewed as the objects of professional ministrations and as the cooperative followers of professional dictates.

Cont...

- It will be more productive for health professionals to strengthen the therapeutic alliance with patients
 - by increasing the level of patient participation and control in decisions that are made about treatment.

Encouraging a more Active Patient role in Therapeutic Monitoring

- Why?
 - The information that a patient provides as part of therapeutic monitoring is essential to ensure that the therapeutic goals are being met.
 - INR AND Hb A_{1c}
 - Rx of depression and pain- self-report as the only basis of evaluation of response to therapy
 - Patient self-monitoring of blood glucose has become the standard practice in managing diabetes

Cont...

- ✓ They have unanswered questions
- ✓ They have misunderstandings
- ✓ They experience problems related to therapy
- ✓ They monitor their own response to treatment
- ✓ They make their own decisions regarding therapy
- ✓ And they may not reveal this information to you unless you initiate the dialogue

The communication model:

Communication is *the **process by** which messages are conveyed.*

- Communication between
 - ▣ sender and receiver
- To optimize communication, we must consider the **“channel”**
- Potential for a breakdown to occur **at any time**
- Barriers will exist – minimize these when you can

Effective Communication

- Is two-way
- Involves active listening
- Reflects the accountability of the speaker and the listener
- Utilizes feedback
- Free of stress
- Clear and concise

Interpersonal Communication



PRINCIPLES AND ELEMENTS OF INTERPERSONAL COMMUNICATION

- Interpersonal communication is a common but complex practice that is essential in dealing with patients and other health care providers
- In our personal and professional lives, we all have to interact with other people
 - successful or not

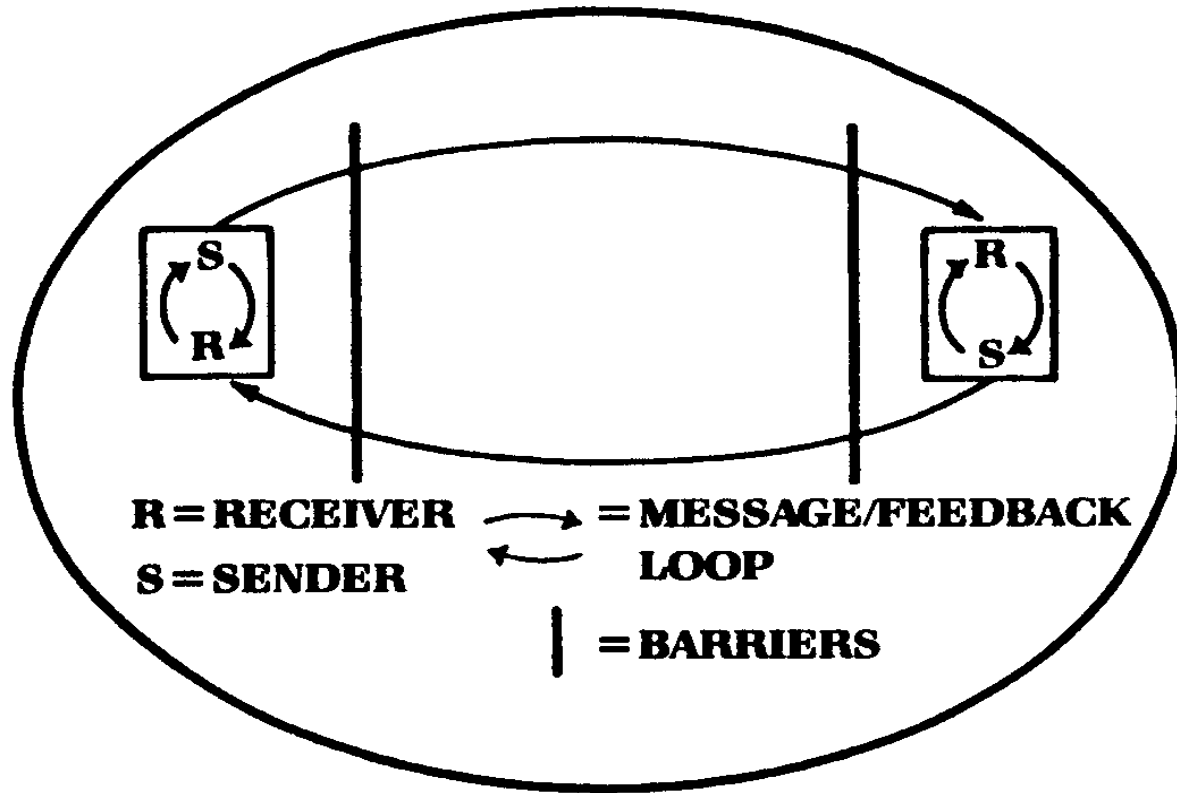
Components of the Interpersonal Communication Model

- **Interpersonal communication** is best described as a process in which messages are generated and transmitted by one person and subsequently received and translated by another.
- The essence of good communication is that the message received is the same as the message sent.

The communication model...

- The Interpersonal communication model has five important elements:
 - Sender
 - Message
 - Receiver
 - Feedback and
 - Barriers.

The interpersonal communication model.



1. Sender

- In the interpersonal communication process, the sender transmits a message to another person
- The sender can try to make sure the message is received correctly by:
 - ✓ speaking clearly
 - ✓ speaking slowly
 - ✓ using appropriate language
 - ✓ checking understanding.

2. Message

- The message is the element that is transmitted from one person to another.
- Messages can be:
 - Thoughts
 - Ideas
 - Emotions
 - Information or other factors
- A message consists of:
 - ✓ factual information transmitted verbally
 - ✓ feeling information transmitted nonverbally

3. The receiver

- Receives the message from the sender
- Decode the message and assign a particular meaning to it, which may or may not be the sender's intended meaning

4. Feedback

- Is the process whereby receivers communicate back the sender their understanding of the sender's message
- In most situations , receivers do not passively absorb messages
 - respond with their own verbal and non-verbal messages
- In the interpersonal communication process, individuals are constantly moving back and forth b/n the roles of sender and receiver.
- Feedback allows communication to be a two-way process

Cont...

□ The feedback loop

- The initial receiver *becomes the sender* of feedback, and the initial sender becomes the *receiver of feedback*.
- So, in the interpersonal communication process, individuals are thus constantly **moving back and forth** between the roles of sender and receiver.
- Feedback can be
 - simple, such as merely nodding your head, or
 - More complex, such as repeating a set of complicated instructions to make sure that you interpreted them correctly.

5. Barriers

- These are interferences that usually affects interpersonal communication
- For example,
 - A loud vacuum cleaner running in pharmacy while you are advising patient
 - Telephone ringing

Responsibility of Pharmacists in the Communication Model

1. Ensuring that the message is transmitted in the clear form, in terminology understood by the other person, and in environment conducive to clear transmission
2. Asking feedback from the receiver and clarify any misunderstandings
3. Aware of the sources of barriers to effective communication that exist and attempt to minimize them

Searching the Meaning of the Message

- The critical component in the interpersonal communication model is that the **receiver assigns the same meaning** to the verbal or nonverbal message as intended by the sender.
- But you may or may not interpret the message's meaning in the same way as sender intended.

Words and Context

- In general, individuals assign meaning to verbal and non-verbal messages based on
 - Their past experience
 - Previous definition of these verbal and non-verbal elements
 - The context that they perceive the sender is using
 - The social context
- So , if two persons do not share the same definition or past experiences, misunderstanding may occur

Cont...

- A 9-month-old baby had to be admitted to the hospital with severe infection because his mother misunderstood the labeled instructions for an antibiotic: “take one-half teaspoonful three times a day for infection until all gone”. The mother continued the drug for about three days until the baby appeared to be getting better. The mother then stopped giving the antibiotic; a superinfection developed, and the baby was hospitalized.

Social Context

- The type of relationship that patients have with their pharmacists determines the level of acceptance that the patients have regarding the information provided.
- If they perceive pharmacists to be trustworthy (credible, unbiased providers of useful information) and honest, they will be more willing to approach pharmacists for assistance.

Congruence between Verbal and Non-verbal Messages

- The meaning of the verbal message is not consistent with the meaning of the non-verbal message.
- The meaning of the message may be somewhat unclear if the receiver senses incongruence b/n verbal and non-verbal messages.
 - the receiver may be confused about the true message intended by the sender.

Cont...

Examples

1. A disappointed pharmacist has tried to convince a physician to change an obvious error in a patient's medication. When asked how he is feeling, he meekly replies, "oh, I am just fine."
2. A patient hands a pharmacist a tranquilizer prescription, then bursts into tears. The pharmacist asks if anything is the matter, and the patient responds, "No, I'm okay, it's nothing at all."



Angry



Happy



Bored



Surprised

Cont...

Statements or questions that elicit feedback

1. "I want to be sure I have explained things clearly. Please summarize the most important things to remember about this medicine."
2. "How do you intend to take the medication?"
3. "Please show me how you are going to use this nasal inhaler?"
4. "It is important that I understand that you know how to take this medication. Now, when you go home, how are you going to take this medication?"
5. "Describe in your own words how you are going to take this medication"

Improving Communication Behaviors

- When attempting to change communication behaviors, it is important to place these potential behavioral changes in relation to two other concepts:
 1. **Awareness and**
 2. **Attitude**
- A change in behavior is frequently built on an appropriate awareness and attitudes that are conducive to potential behavioral change

Cont...

- Awareness of the communication process centers on two important concepts:
 1. Self-awareness
 2. Process awareness
- Self-awareness
 - The process of recognizing how you are actually communicating with others using both verbal and non-verbal messages.
 - The process of analyzing how you are communicating at the actual time of the interaction.

Cont...

- Self-awareness
 - Part of this process is asking questions such as
 - “What type of non-verbal messages am I sending?”
 - “Am I using the correct terminology for this patient?”
- How to enhance self-awareness?
 - Video typing in simulated or actual practice settings
 - Critique from colleagues, administrators or faculty

Cont...

- **Process awareness**

- involves analyzing the communication process itself while it is occurring

Questions to be asked

- ✓ Is the conversion going in the direction it should go?
- ✓ Are we getting sidetracked?

How to Prevent Misperceptions and Misunderstanding

- Avoid use of equivocal terms (words with more than one meaning).
- Avoid use of professional jargon.
- Use simple ideas.
- Use simple words.
- Recognize the differences in cross-cultural styles of speaking.
- Avoid stereotypes: elder people can not hear well.

Non-verbal communication

- Words are not the only way by which pharmacists communicate.
- Interpersonal communication involves both verbal and nonverbal expression.
- Non-verbal communication involves a complex mix of behavior, psychological responses, and environmental interactions through which a person consciously and unconsciously relates to another person.

Cont...

- Words normally express ideas, whereas nonverbal expressions convey attitudes and emotions.
- A large measure of how you relate to others and how they relate to you is not based on what is said but on what is not said.
- You may not speak or even have the desire to communicate, and yet be engaged in a communication process.
- You are constantly providing “messages” to those around you by your dress, facial expression, body movements, and other aspects of your appearance and behavior.

Cont...

- There are two core purposes of nonverbal behavior
 1. *Message comprehension and recall* are facilitated by the use of nonverbal behaviors, such as communicative gestures (e.g., raising three fingers to signal 'three' of something).
 2. *Relational communication*, such as the expression of liking and friendship, is conveyed by a range of behaviours including: direct body and facial orientation, a close conversational distance, consistent eye contact, head nods, a forward leaning and open posture, smiles and pleasant facial expressions, frequent gestures, and appropriate touch.

Verbal vs. Non-verbal Communication

Verbal

- Words normally express ideas
- The media of exchange are either the vocal language or the written word.

Non-verbal

- Non-verbal expressions convey attitudes and emotions
- Media of exchange is neither the vocal language nor the written word.



Boredom



Interest



Fear

Examples of different non-verbal communications.

Important Elements of Nonverbal Communication

- Body language (Kinesics)
- Distance (Proxemics)
- Vocalics (paralanguage)
- Touch (haptics)
- Environment

Kinesics

- The manner in which you use your arms, legs, hands, head, face, and torso may have a dramatic impact on the messages that you send. E.g. handshaking
 - Posture
 - Gesture
 - Facial expression
- As a health care professional, you need to generate a feeling of empathy and commitment to helping others → . Your body movement should complement this role.

Key Components of Kinesics

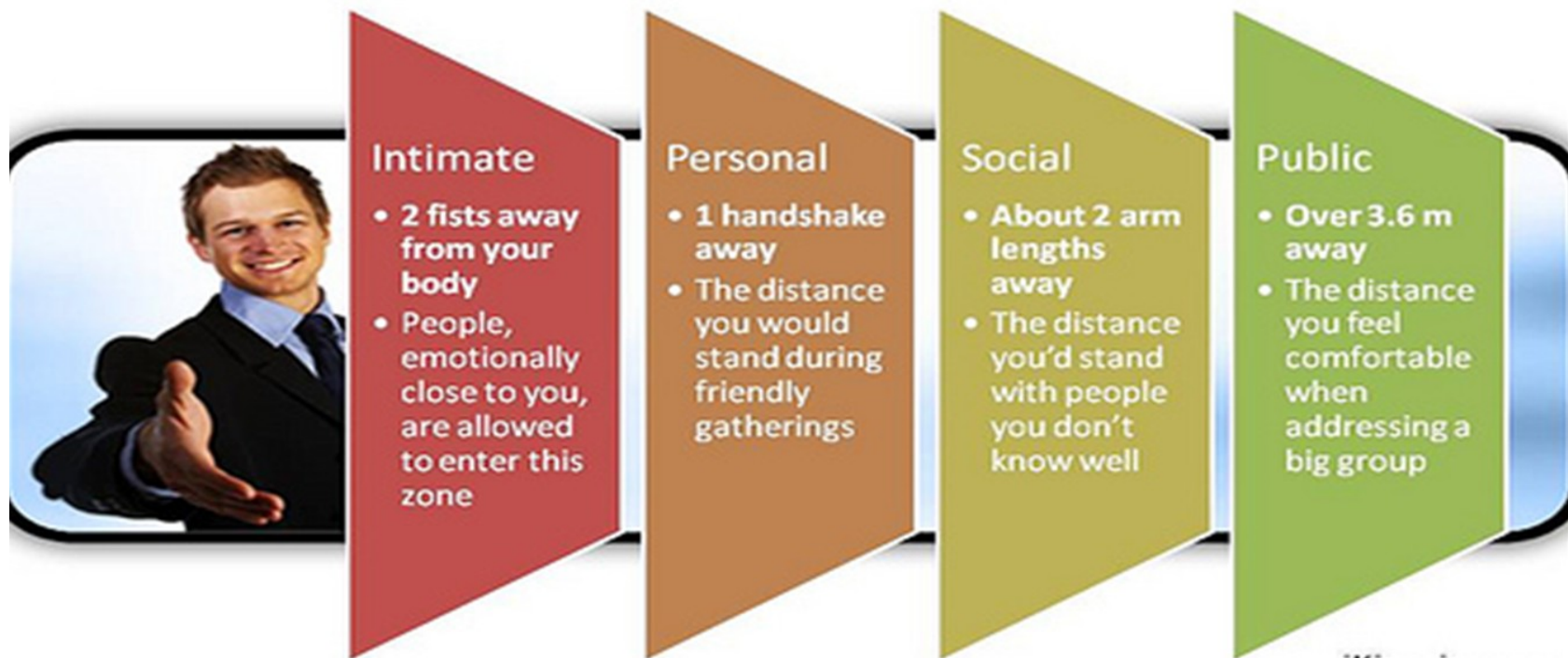
- Varied eye contact (consistent, but not a stare)
- Relaxed posture
- Appropriate comfortable posture
- Frontal appearance (shoulders square to the other person)
- Erect body position (head up, shoulders back).

Proxemics

- The structure and use of space (the distance between two interacting persons).
- Behavioral scientists have found that the quality of interactions can vary depending on the distances between the communicators.
 - You do not want to invade a patient's intimate zone nor conduct the counseling session in the public zone.

Proxemics

The distances between two or more individuals.



iKinesics.com

Environmental factors

- Many environmental factors play important roles in communicating nonverbal messages to patients.
 - For example, the colors used in the pharmacy's decor, the lighting, and the use of space.

Distracting Factors: lack of eye contact

- Lack of eye contact indicates to patients that
 - You are not really confident about what you are saying
 - You do not really care about the patient
- Lack of eye contact limits your ability to receive feedback from the patient.
- Using good eye contact does not mean that you continually stare at patients, but that you spend most of the time looking at them.

Distracting Factors: facial expression

- Another potentially distracting non-verbal element is facial expression.
- ✓ e.g. if you moving your eye around while talking or listening to another person, you may be communicating a feeling of lack of interest or concern.
- Unintended facial expression may send a message that you did not intend to transmit.

Distracting Factors: body position

- Most patients will judge your willingness to talk to them based on their perception of your body position.

Distracting Factors: tone of the voice

- People interpret the message not only by the words you use, but also by the tone of the voice you use.

e.g., conveying a message in a monotone voice may convey a lack of interest in the communication.

Distracting Factors: manner of use of time

- The manner in which you use time also conveys a number of silent messages.

e.g. if you cut counseling session short to answer the telephone , you are sending non-verbal messages that your time is more valuable than that of others.

Barriers to Communication

- Interpersonal communication is usually affected by several **interferences or barriers**.
- These barriers affect the accuracy of the communication exchange
- Within the communication process, numerous barriers exist that may **disrupt or even eliminate** interpersonal interaction.

Cont...

- As a sender, you are responsible for ensuring that the message is transmitted in the clearest form, in
 - ▣ **terminology** understood by the other person, and
 - ▣ an **environment** conducive to clear transmission.

Cont...

- Barrier is one of the **five elements** in interpersonal communication.
- Minimizing communication barriers typically requires a two-stage process:
 - ✓ First, you must be aware that they exist.
 - ✓ Second, you need to take appropriate action to overcome them.

Environmental Barriers

- The environment in which communication takes place is critical in pharmacy practice, and distractions within the environment often interfere with this process.
- One of the most obvious barriers in most community practice settings is the height of the prescription counter separating patients from pharmacy personnel.

Cont...

- Ringing telephones, elevated work areas, people talking in the background, and a lack of privacy are all barriers to interactive communication in a community pharmacy.
- They may lead patients to feel that the pharmacists are not accessible or not interested in providing answers to their questions.

Cont...

- Many community pharmacies are designing or redesigning their pharmacy area to diminish or eliminate environmental barriers.
- While it is desirable to have a quiet and at least somewhat private area for pharmacist-patient discussions, simply turning away from obstacles and distractions and facing the patient can be very helpful.

Personal Barriers

- ❑ Many personal characteristics can lead to distractions in communication.
- ❑ Lack of confidence in your personal ability to communicate effectively may influence how you communicate.
- ❑ If you believe that you cannot communicate well or are rather shy, you may avoid talking to others.

Cont...

- ❑ Many people feel that an effective communication style is something you are born with, and may use shyness as an excuse to avoid interacting with others.
- ❑ Unfortunately, people do not realize that communication skills can be learned and developed.
- ❑ However, like other skills, they require practice and reinforcement.

Potential Pharmacist-Related Personal Barriers

- ❑ Low self-confidence
- ❑ Shyness
- ❑ Dysfunctional internal monologue
- ❑ Lack of objectivity
- ❑ Cultural differences
- ❑ Discomfort in sensitive situations
- ❑ Negative perceptions about the value of patient interaction

Administrative Barriers

- Several factors dealing with the administrative aspects of pharmacy practice serve as barriers to communication.

For example, most community practitioners are not paid directly for educating or communicating with patients.

Time Barriers

- ❑ Choosing an inappropriate time to initiate a conversation may lead to communication failure.
- ❑ The timing of the interaction is critical, since both parties must be ready to communicate at a given time.
- ❑ Timing within institutional practice is also critical, since health care providers are performing multiple tasks in very active environments.

Functional Barriers

- Deal primarily with patient characteristics such as vision and hearing impairments, language differences, low literacy, and comprehension difficulties.
- Many of these may be difficult to detect.
- People with hearing or vision impairment may not wear their hearing aids or glasses.

Cont...

- Some may be unaware of their hearing impairment as they can "hear" but may have difficulty distinguishing some sounds, which can lead to misunderstanding words.
- Low literacy can be especially challenging.

Generally,

- ❑ Interpersonal communication, because of its complexity and human involvement, is a fragile process.
- ❑ Messages become helpful to others only when they are accurately received and understood.
- ❑ If messages are distorted or incorrect, they actually may be harmful to patient care and interpersonal relationships.
- ❑ Failure to communicate may lead to negative patient outcomes.
- ❑ Barriers may lead to distortion of messages and misunderstandings between you and others.

Thank you !!